The Congress failed to secure a majority in parliament during the 1989 election, resulting in V.P. Singh's ascent to the office of prime minister as head of a minority government. He lasted in power for only eleven months (from December 1989 to November 1990). During Singh's tenure, the government's weak grip allowed little room for major foreign policy initiatives. Singh's foreign minister, veteran Congressman Inder Kumar Gujral, ran foreign policy without much guidance from the prime minister. V.P. Singh was one of those prime ministers who had little knowledge or interest in external affairs, whereas Gujral was passionate about foreign policy. Gujral had served as ambassador to Moscow from 1976 to 1980. He later became external affairs minister again in 1996 and prime minister at the head of a coalition government in 1997–98. Gujral saw himself as reviving Nehru's idealism albeit with a vengeance. He is known most for his Gujral doctrine, forsaking reciprocity in relations with India's immediate neighbours and offering them unilateral concessions. [129]



Gujral's detractors fault him for his extreme idealism reflected in the Gujral doctrine as well as his belief that foreign and defence policy only meant diplomacy, not the hard side of intelligence gathering. Under Gujral, India's covert intelligence capabilities were drastically reduced and they hurt India's diplomatic potential. India's intelligence gathering offices in many countries, not only the neighbours but also beyond, were wound up. One immediate impact of this was felt when a coup in Fiji took place. India had a huge diaspora in that country and the winding up of India's intelligence capabilities meant India did not find out about the incident till much later.

The defining moment in Gujral's first stint as Singh's foreign minister came when Gujral chose to be photographed hugging Saddam Hussein while India wavered in supporting the US-led coalition against Iraq during the war over Kuwait. Iraq's invasion of Kuwait in August 1990 was almost